RIKU YUKI DARROCH

THE DESIGNER

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INTRODUCTION

My name is Riku Yuki Darroch. I am 22 years old and a fourth year student eager to graduate this year. I study at Victoria University of Wellington and my degree is in Design Innovation majoring in Communication Design. However, my curiosity has lead me to take courses in many other disciplines including Game Design, Media Design, Animation, Film Studies and even Linguistics and Humanities.

I grew up in Te Anau, a small town in Southland New Zealand, and with my Japanese Mother I have been back and forth between there and visiting family in Ebetsu, Hokkaido, Japan. As a result, I struggled with my identity, however I now embrace my cultural background and use it as inspiration for my work as a designer.

I consider my curiosity to be one of my biggest strengths. I parituclary love finding inspirations from unlikely places; of course from projects by people in my field, but also from music, politics, history and sciences. I particularly resonate with themes of class inequality, environmentalism, cultural cross-pollination, and social commentary.

My creative pracitce is primarily in the field of illustration/digital painting, however I also have experience in video production/editing, game design, writing, creative ideation, audio production and life drawing.

CREATIVITY IS DIVINE

The reason why I made this career decision is because I believe in the power of expressing ideas through creative fields and its ability to inhibit change. Art as a career is often seen as a non essential job, finding itself first at the chopping block whenever convenient by those in power. But the ability to express ideas through art is something that not many other forms of communication can replicate quite as effectively. I am sure you have watched a movie that taught you about yourself or changed the way that you view the world. Perhaps not quantifiably, but the way that creative projects teach about abstract concepts is so valuable and I want to harness that. There is a magic you feel when you listen to a beautiful song or see a beautiful painting that no amount of scientific analysis is capable of describing. It's that mysterious power that art holds that is meaningful. No matter when or where, innately humanity fights to create, whether under an oppressive regime or on the cave man walls. Maybe to call out to the cosmos to prove that we were real once, or to be remembered in the future, perhaps there is something divine about creating that keeps us picking up our tools.

"A Earth without art is just a rock" - Kendrick Lamar

RED-MOON CONCEPT ART (2024)

This is a painting I did in a course about Concept Art and World Building. This was painted as part of my concept world called “Red Moon” and was accompanied with a pitch deck explaining my vision. I painted this digitally using Clip Studio Paint and touched up the colors in PhotoShop.

“Red Moon” is a paranormal post apocalyptic Sci-Fi world where in a response to global overconsumption the Earth starts distributing supernatural abilities and mutations to living beings that make living much more dangerous. Therefore humanity flees sparsely populated areas to protected mega-cities leaving places like the South Island of New Zealand completely abandoned. However, there are humans that recieved these abilities and a global arms race to acquire these gifted people for political and strategic gain takes place. These gifted individuals are tasked with protecting humanity from the dangerous beings, unravelling the mystery around the supernatural abilities while also being tangled in a web of politics.

This painting was influenced by my time growing up in Te Anau. My father was a skipper at Milford Sound and as a child I would spend a lot of time there with my family. I recall the times in the late afternoon once the tourists had left, leaving the fjord quiet and timid, disconnected from society. The vehicle featured in this painting was inspired from mechanical design in Bladerunner 2049, The Dark Night, and Star Wars. The greater concept around the world was inspired by Fullmetal Alchemist, The Last of Us, Metal Gear Solid and Bladerunner 2049.

I am particularly proud of the rendering in the background and the insinuation of depth using varying opacity. I am also proud of the vehical and it’s jagged design. I found that the cinematic 16:9 aspect ratio really dramaticized the image in a way I liked. However I originally painted this piece in a rush and I didn’t consider the design of the craft and the characher quite as much as I would have liked. I would like to redo this painting at some point after having redesigned these aspects and refined my artstyle.

THE DEATH DEVIL MONSTER DESIGN (2024)

This is a painting that I did as a part of a Comics and Graphic Novels course. The assignment was to design a new element to an existing comic. The comic I chose for this project was the popular Shonen Jump series "Chainsaw Man" by Tatsuki Fujimoto. The element I designed was what I imagined the Death Devil would look like as at the time it hadn't yet been revealed. I painted this piece digitally on Clip Studio Paint and touched the colors up on Photoshop.

In "Chainsaw Man", the strength of devils are scaled by how the concept the devil represents is feared by humans. At the time, "The Landing of Nostre Damus" was foreshadowed for upwards of 50 chapters profesizing the arrival of the Death Devil to Earth from Hell. Previously we saw in the manga the Gun Devil which was a towering humanoid being, therefore I imagined the Death Devil would be the same.

The thing that influenced me the most for this piece was a model of the human nervous system that I had found online. I wanted the being to relate to the human experience while also seeming alien and Lovecraftian. Death is often represented by the skeleton, however I believed the nervous system had untapped potential in body-horror. I took inspiration from the Founding Titan in the final season of Attack on Titan, "The General Zapped an Angel" the painting by Karel Thole in 1970, and the structure of viruses in biology for the shape design of this being.

I am proud of this piece as it represents a turning point in my art style. I like the usage of color and the texturing of the bones. I think the artsyle and monster design reflects the source material's. Although I wish now that at the time I was more thoughtful with the actual shape of the being, and also a bit more adventurous with the composition and posing.

FROM THE ABYSS TO THE TREES (2024)

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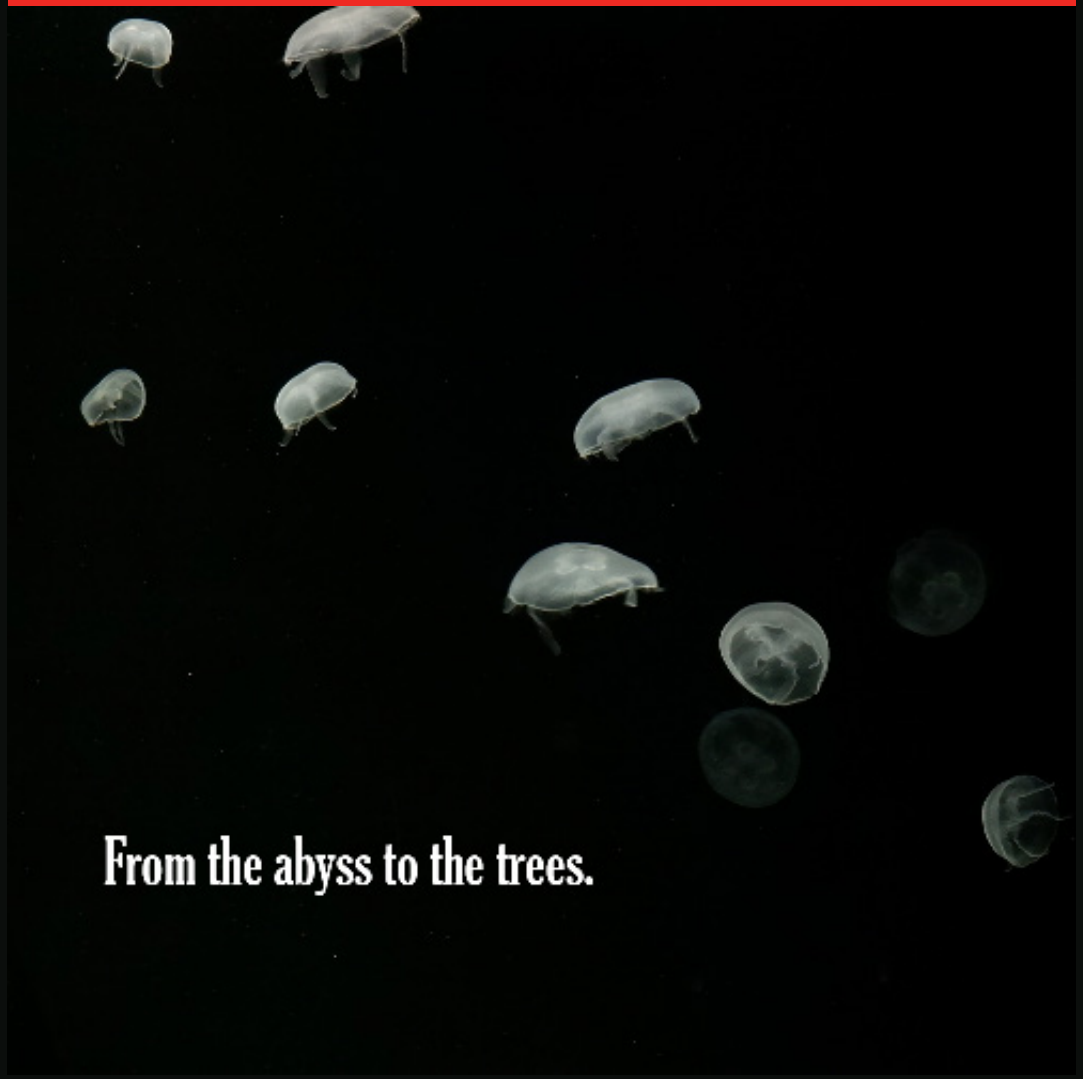

This is a soundscape/song that I developed as part of a course in media design. It is composed of field recordings of the ocean, rustling trees and birdsounds, then periodically shifting to my girlfriend playing the piano. This song is a subtle and somber reminder of the importance of nature and the origin of life on Earth. I composed this project using Adobe Audition.

This song was mainly influenced by the soundtrack of Nintendo's The Legend of Zelda Breath of the Wild, particularly the quiet tracks where the diegetic sounds of the game fade in and out in real time with the subtle piano. Another inspiration was C418's 2018 album "Excursions" with it's nature field recordings and sobre limited instruments.

At the time I had no experience in music composition or soundscape production so there were many challenges in the composition of this project. An example was the piano recordings cut off prematurely, so I had to fade out the keys by stitching different recordings together, creating an unsettling tune to the piano. Along with the piano itself being out of tune. However, I thoroughly enjoyed recording the sounds for the soundscape as I had taken the audio recorder to the beach in Owhiro Bay and to Zealandia and I had managed to capture a very clean recording of a bellbird's call.
I am proud of this project being my introduction to audio production, however I would like to redo it now that I am a little more in tune with the practice, I would also like to redesign the album cover too.

THANK YOU FOR READING